

and consistency of the wind. When the wind is with your opponent, shorten the backswing on your groundstrokes and make your volleys even more compact. Otherwise, a late swing often results in an error, because your margin of error is much smaller on very windy days.

Conversely, press your advantage when the wind is at your back. You have more time to attack with topspin groundstrokes; you can overpower one-handed backhands; and your kick serves will bounce higher, and your slice serves will swerve wider. But beware of your opponent's weak, underspin, mishit, or fluke shots that land in the forecourt and are held up or buffeted by the wind. These oncoming balls can prove tricky if you misjudge and then mistime them.

Finally, lateral winds, especially gusts, can blow a ball out of your reach or in too close to your torso. They force you to realign your position quickly to try to contact the ball in the 'strike zone'. Just as important, lateral winds require you to shorten your backswing and hit 'through the ball' as much as possible to control the shot. To that end, respect the percentages and go for less power and placement to reduce your errors.

Note the speed, levelness, and uniformity of the surface: All other things being equal, the faster the surface, the less time you have to run and hit the ball. A tilted surface changes the angle of incidence of the bounce. And a heavily used clay court, a worn-down grass court, and a cracked hard court will produce uneven and unpredictable bounces that can disrupt your timing. The solution is to move your feet more than normal. Take small steps with a wide stance (each foot moving a small distance from its previous position) to adjust for strange bounces and to maintain a stable platform to support your shot. Note the speed of the ball and estimate

how much the balls slow down and bounce lower — either by losing compression, becoming fluffy, or getting cold or wet — during the match. Make sure to modulate your swing so you keep the correct contact point, rather than hit the ball in front of it.

Let your senses guide your timing

Watch the ball intently and as long as possible: Roger Federer was renowned for turning his head on groundstrokes as the ball came within a yard of his contact point so that his eyes stayed focused on the ball through the contact point. He also kept his head still, further aiding his sighting. As a result, the 20-time Major champion timed the ball exceedingly well and could adjust quickly to any abrupt or unpredictable late changes in the flight of the ball. Similarly, the best servers like Serena Williams and Carlos Alcaraz keep their heads up as long as possible to watch the ball for as long as they can.

Listen to the sound of your opponent's shot: Evaluate the solidity of it to help determine its speed and spin. Then adjust your timing accordingly. Your vigilant, experienced eyes can often tell when your opponent's shot is contacted outside the 'sweet spot' and thus will produce less power and perhaps an unpredictable spin.

Know where you're positioned on the court when you hit the ball: In my 2021 instruction book, *The Fein Points of Tennis*, I wrote about the 'sixth sense': "When hitting shots on the run, world-class competitors have a sixth sense that tells them exactly where they're positioned. In sharp contrast, recreational players lack this court awareness and, as a result, often hit the wrong shot or err."

This positional awareness applies to returning short shots, deep shots, angle shots, and most importantly, wide shots. When your opponent forces you to hit the ball from outside the singles sideline (or even beyond the doubles sideline) for a passing shot or a go-for-broke down-the-line winner, strike the ball earlier, thus more in front of your usual contact point to keep your shot in the court. Rafael Nadal, the legendary King of Clay, exemplified perfect forehand timing in these two sprinting scenarios.

Understand how stroke technique affects timing

Note the ideal contact point for each stroke: For example, the contact point for a one-handed backhand is about six inches farther in front and thus comes earlier than for a two-handed backhand. Also, the contact point for the Western forehand is farther in front of the body than the semi-Western forehand; and the contact point for the semi-Western forehand is farther in front than that of the Eastern forehand. The contact point for crosscourt forehands and backhands is more in front and thus comes earlier than for their down-the-line

